

companies abroad. The modus operandi consisted of the Indian company buying a foreign firm with whose owner the Indian promoters already had an understanding. The Indian promoter would pay a certain amount for the acquisition, more than half of which would be returned by the foreign owner later.

---

I am embarrassed to tell you what my paper wealth had grown to by the last week of February that year. All I will say is that it was substantial enough for me to have lost count of it.

‘Lala, has it occurred that you must have made more money than Shah Rukh Khan over the last one year?’ Monk remarked the day after the Budget, when a group of us had gathered at a restaurant. I mentally calculated my net worth, and was flattered to realize that Monk was right after all.

‘I never thought of it that way, but I guess it must be true,’ I said, both delighted and embarrassed at the same time.

‘Of course it is true, Lala. Tell me something, why are you still working after having made so much money?’ Monk asked with a grin.

‘For the same reason that you come to work every day despite having made more money than perhaps Shah Rukh Khan and Aamir Khan put together,’ I said.

My repartee drew laughter from everybody at the table. I thought I saw a flash of anger briefly flicker in Monk’s eyes before he joined the others in the laughter.

I knew I had overstepped my boundaries with Monk and had to make amends quickly. Monk could discuss my net worth in public, but I was not to take the same liberty with him.

‘. . . for the same reason Ketan Parekh comes to work every day or, for that matter, even Warren Buffet, to make more money,’ I continued.

Monk smiled. Sipping his drink, he said, ‘What I like about Lala as a trader is that he is good at sensing market trends and will quickly get out of a loss-making trade.’

Nobody at the table caught what Monk was getting at, but I did.

---